platform on May 1. With all the synchronised classical dances and angst and broken hearts in the story, Bhansali has called it his tribute to Kamal Amrohi's *Pakeezah*, Mehboob Khan's *Mother India* and K. Asif's *Mughal-e-Azam*. As Bollywood biggies avoid cinemas in May owing to the ongoing Lok Sabha election, *Heeramandi* has become the de facto biggest release of the month.

Jewel in the Pack

Netflix certainly knows the significance of the project. The trailer launch was just one of the many shindigs the OTT platform organised. In March, they had drones to unveil the release date of the show at the Mahalaxmi Race Course in Mumbai; a year earlier, they had hosted an interaction with Bhansali and Netflix CEO Ted Sarandos, where the latter described the filmmaker as among the "rare breed of creators" who deliver "style and substance in equal measure". Proof of *Heeramandi's* clout in the Netflix roster is that it is the first to have had a special screening at the Egyptian Theatre in Los Angeles and is the platform's first Indian series to be dubbed in Arabic, Malay, French, Thai and German.

In the Netflix India originals universe, *Heeramandi* is a bit of an anomaly. "Actually, no project starts like this," says Shergill. She is referring to the series' journey, which began with Bhansali heading to Los Angeles in 2019 to meet Sarandos to discuss the idea of bringing alive his 14-year-old passion project to their platform. Sarandos was glad to have a cinematic and distinctive idea, even more so after Bhansali's *Gangubai Kathiawadi* became a hit on Netflix in 2022, trending in the global top 10 for non-English films for six weeks in 47 countries. Bhansali was in no mood to "curb his ambition and vision", says Prerna Singh, who became a middle(wo)man between him and Netflix. "Most take a compromised approach because it's the small screen, but SLB always gives a cinematic experience," says Singh. "He told me, '*Mujhe freedom do* [give me freedom] to make it the way I want to'."

What this meant was replicating the Heeramandi of Lahore in the undivided India of the 1940s, a district known for its artistically gifted *tawaifs* (courtesans)—in Mumbai's Film City. Nearly 700 labourers spent seven months building and designing the sets spread across 150,000 square feet, with some structures standing 45 feet tall. In the Bhansali universe, the green screen is a sore sight that should be avoided as far as possible and beauty lies even in inanimate objects. So, the walls had hand-painted flowers and portraits, inscribed mirrors, and furniture was 'aged' to look antique. At the interaction with Sarandos last year, Bhansali had mentioned how, for his streaming debut, he had made the scale "even bigger", calling *Heeramandi* "the biggest set I have made in my life". "There's no holding back or trying to think differently for OTT." Shergill spoke of the mammoth task of lighting the sets; another Netflix representative recalled the aroma of fresh flowers and *attar* that hung in the air on the set during the shoot.



Making *Heeramandi*

- **The series is said to be Netflix India's most expensive till date, made at a rumoured budget of Rs 200 crore**
- **Four years in the making, the eight-episode series saw nearly 700 labourers spending seven months building and designing the sets spread across 150,000 sq. feet**
- **The Sanjay Leela Bhansali series is the platform's first Indian title to be dubbed in Arabic, Malay, French, Thai and German, and to have a special screening at the Egyptian Theatre in LA**

A Whole New World

The 380-day-long shoot—taking over a year and a half—was like making three films, Bhansali said during the interaction with Sarandos. Yet it was uncharted territory for the multi-hyphenate creator. There was a "lot to learn and unlearn" through the process, says Prerna Singh. The long-format storytelling necessitated adding characters and building individual